

NORTHERN SOUTH AMERICA

ARCHING AROUND THE RAIN FORESTS of the great Amazon River, the countries in northern South America are dominated by the Andes Mountains. Running north to south from Venezuela to Ecuador, and then through Chile, the mountains were once home to the Inca Empire. In search of gold, the Spanish arrived in the 16th century and carved out a huge empire. British, French, and Dutch colonies were also established in the northeast. Except for French Guiana, these are now independent, although not without problems. Extremes of wealth and poverty, overcrowded cities, and the illegal drug trade are features of most countries in this region.

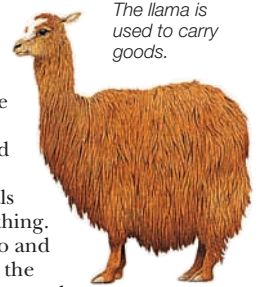


QUECHUA INDIANS

The Quechua have lived high in the Andes in Bolivia, Peru, and Ecuador for hundreds of years. The Quechua were once farmers and shared common land equally between men and women. Today, many Quechua have moved to the cities in search of work. Those who remain farm tiny plots of land.

ANIMALS OF THE ANDES

For centuries, the people of the Andes have relied on a group of versatile mammals for food and clothing. The wild guanaco and vicuña, as well as the domesticated llama and alpaca, are treasured for their wool and meat. Vicuña wool is as fine as silk, while coarse llama wool is used to make blankets, ropes, and other goods.



The llama is used to carry goods.

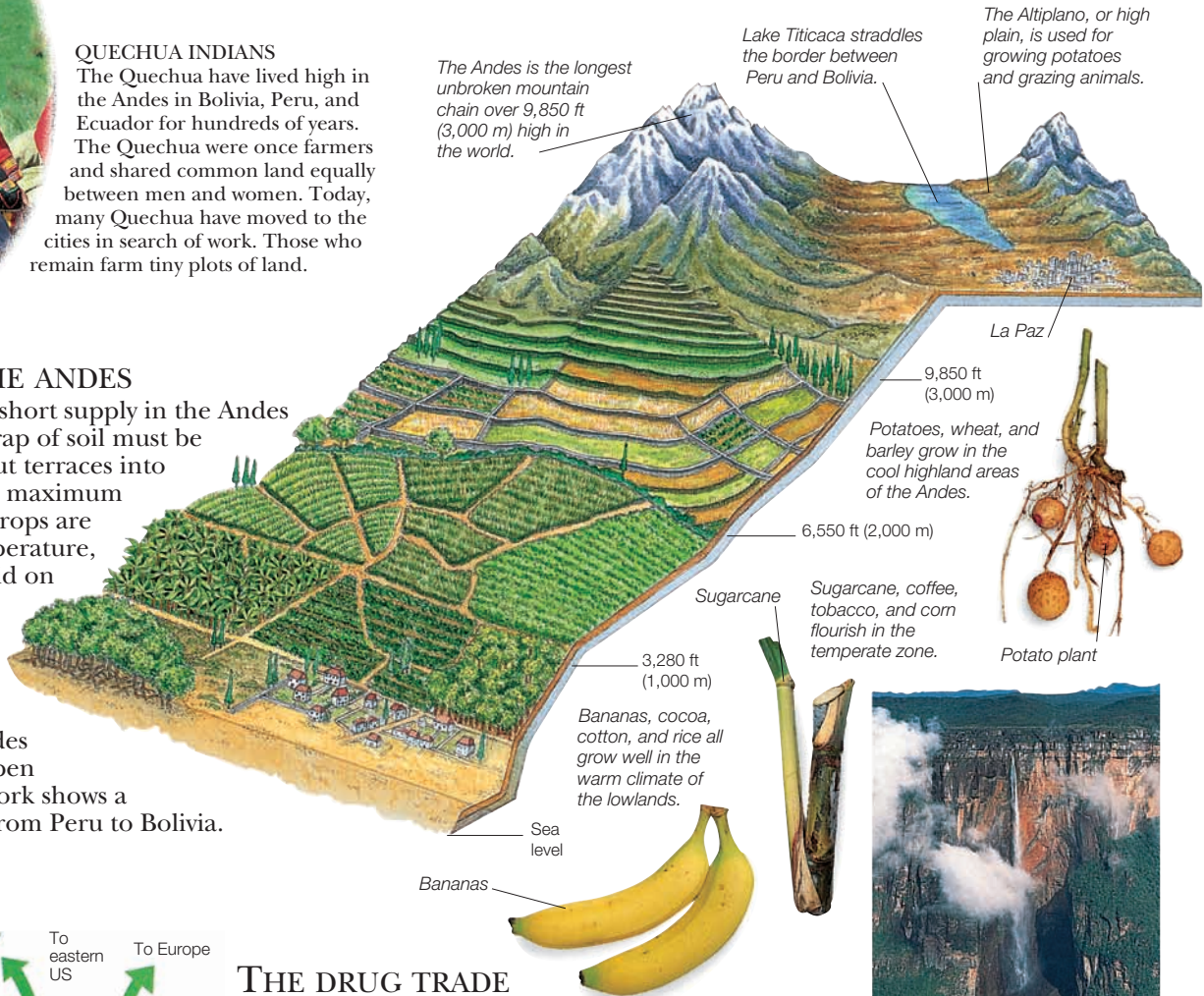
Lake Titicaca straddles the border between Peru and Bolivia.

The Altiplano, or high plain, is used for growing potatoes and grazing animals.

The Andes is the longest unbroken mountain chain over 9,850 ft (3,000 m) high in the world.

CULTIVATING THE ANDES

Fertile land is in such short supply in the Andes that every available scrap of soil must be used. Farmers often cut terraces into the hillsides to get the maximum use from their land. Crops are grown to suit the temperature, which is hot and humid on the lower slopes near the coast, but gets cooler as the mountains rise upward. On the high plains beyond the Andes only the potato will ripen successfully. This artwork shows a section of the Andes from Peru to Bolivia.



World drug routes



THE DRUG TRADE

For many centuries, people in this region have chewed the leaves of the coca plant to reduce hunger. Today the leaves are processed to make cocaine, an illegal drug much in demand in North America and Europe. Coca bushes thrive on poor soil and need little attention, unlike food crops, which need tending. Growing coca is also more profitable than growing food. As a result, large quantities of coca are grown in isolated areas of the Andes. Once refined into cocaine, the drug is smuggled out of the region.

ANGEL FALLS

Angel Falls is the highest waterfall in the world. It was discovered in 1935 by Jimmy Angel, an American pilot who was flying across Venezuela in search of a river he had once prospected for gold. Instead he flew over a vast waterfall that plunges 3,215 ft (980 m) into the Churún River below.

